Kavya Ravindranath

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Education

George Washington University
Ph.D. Economics, expected May 2027

Madras School of Economics, India
M.A. Economics, 2019

St. Xavier's College, India
B.A. Economics, 2017

Fields

Primary: Public Economics, Development Economics

Secondary: Political Economy, Environmental Economics

References

Dr. Elira Kuka (Chair)
ekuka@gwu.edu

Dr. Tanner Regan
tanner_regan@gwu.edu

Dr. Paul Carrillo
pcarrill@gwu.edu

Dr. Remi Jedwab
jedwab@gwu.edu

Working Papers

Raising Revenues: Evidence from Property Tax Assessments in India *(Job Market Paper)*

Abstract: How do property owners respond to increases in property-tax liabilities, and how does heterogeneity in these behavioral responses affect the revenue-maximizing tax rate? I construct a novel dataset of geolocated properties and digitized parcel-level maps from an Indian municipality to answer these questions. Exploiting quasi-random variation arising from area-based property assessments, I find that raising liabilities increases total revenue but reduces compliance, with an overall revenue elasticity of 0.85. Compliance responses vary substantially across the liability distribution, property owners initially facing higher liabilities exhibit larger negative responses. Accounting for this heterogeneity halves the revenue-maximizing tax rate, from four times to twice the current rate. Finally, I find that updating area-based assessment to reflect revenue-maximizing rates would lead to large gains in revenue, but simply updating outdated assessments to more recent values would recover a substantial share of these gains.

Bridging the Solar Divide: Demand Responses to Subsidies among Low-Income Households with Rui Zhong

Abstract: Governments increasingly rely on subsidies to encourage household adoption of clean technology, yet credible estimates of demand elasticities for low-income households, remain limited. In this paper, we study demand responses to solar subsidies in California. Using an RDD, we find a large price elasticity of -1.7.

Political Economy of State Borrowing and Financial Crowding Out with Viral Acharya, Nirupama Kulkarni, and Rahul Singh Chauhan

Abstract: Using regulatory primary auction data of state government securities, we find states with the same ruling party as the central government increase issuance by 28% at 43 bps lower yields in the year before elections. The crowding out mechanism operates through government-owned banks, who bid 23% higher amounts and at a 70 bps discount relative to other bidders. Consequently, firms with a 10% higher share of PSB borrowing see a 9.3% reduction in debt. Finally, we establish the underlying political economy channel wherein aligned states increase consumption expenditure, which increases the probability of the ruling party getting re-elected.

Papers in Progress

Pass-Through of Consumption Taxes under Political Pressure with Sai Pitre

Digital Land and Property Improvement Tax Payment Mechanism in Malawi with Klaus W. Deininger and Daniel Ayalew Ali , Pre-registered trial

How much influence does a bureaucrat have? A study of caste and crime in India

Policy Publications

Progressive tax rate bands and the state of property tax in Kampala
with Nathaniel Badalov, Julius Mutebi, Tanner Regan and Ezra Ssebuwufu
International Growth Centre, 2025

Understanding Sovereign Ratings and Their Implications for Emerging Economies
with Nirupama Kulkarni, Gautham Udupa, Kaushalendra Kishore, Ilisa Goenka and Rahul Singh Chauhan
Economic & Political Weekly, 2023

Seminars & Conferences

2027 - ASSA (Poster)

2026 - World Bank/IFS/ODI Tax Conference (Discussant), GW Development Tea, Georgetown DMV PhD Conference on Political Economy & Development, NEUDC, NTA, APPAM*

2024 - GW Applied Micro Brown Bag Lunch

2023 - World Bank/IFS/ODI Tax Conference, GW Applied Micro Brown Bag Lunch

* *Presented by co-author*

Fellowships & Awards

Lincoln Institute of Land Policy C. Lowell Harriss Dissertation Fellowship: 2026

John W. Kendrick Endowed Summer Award: 2023, 2024, 2025

GW CCAS Doctoral Fellowship: 2021 – 2025

Research Experience

Consultant - World Bank DECRG, Dec 2025–Aug 2026; *PI: Dr. Klaus Deininger*

Research Associate, 2025–2026; *PI: Dr. Elira Kuka*

Consultant - International Finance Corporation, Summer 2025

Research Associate, Summer 2023, Summer 2024; *PI: Dr. Tanner Regan*

Research Associate - Energy and Environment Lab, University of Chicago, Summer 2022; *PIs: Dr. Fiona Burlig, Dr. Ludovica Gazze*

Research Associate - Center for Advanced Financial Research and Learning, Reserve Bank of India, 2019–2021; *PI: Dr. Nirupama Kulkarni*

Memberships

NTA, AEA, APPAM, AREUEA

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Principles of Microeconomics: Fall 2021: *Prof Anthony Yezer*; Spring 2021, Fall 2022, Fall 2024: *Prof Daniel Mackay*

Teaching Assistant, Principles of Macroeconomics: Spring 2022, Fall 2023: *Prof Ronald Bird*; Spring 2024: *Prof Roberto Samaniego*

Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Econometrics: Spring 2025: *Prof Alessandra Fenizia*

Technical skills

Software: Stata, Python, LaTeX, R, SQL
GIS: QGIS, ArcGIS
Other: Git, Qualtrics, Tableau

Citizenship

India, valid work authorization for the United States

Languages

English, Hindi, Tamil, Spanish (beginner)